NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣9

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3♣
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣9

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦Q

Board: 5
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥8

Board: 6
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 4
♥ A K 6
♦ K Q J
♣ J 5 4 3

♠ A
♥ 10 8 5 2
♦ 9 8 5 3
♣ A 10 8 7



♠ 7 3 2
♥ J 9 7 4 3
♦ A 10 6
♣ 9 2

♠ K 10 9 8 6 5
♥ Q
♦ 7 4 2
♣ K Q 6

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♥
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♣9

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer so you bid 2♠. Partner now bids 4♠ and you pass.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♣9. West takes the ♣A, then returns the ♣7 on which East plays the ♣2.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 3

Careful! Although it looks like only 3 losers you are in real danger of a ♣ ruff. It is almost certain that East has led a doubleton ♣ so if West can get the lead with either ♠A or ♦A they will get the ruff.

Fortunately your ♦s are solid and you do not need the ♥Q as a winner.

So before playing any trumps play ♥ A K, discarding dummy's ♣K. That's a lot of winners you are wasting but you can afford it.

Only then can you afford to play a ♠. West can win the ♠A, but if he plays a ♣ dummy will be able to over-ruff East.

After you pull trumps you can drive out the ♦A and claim the contract.

As you see, trying even one round of trumps would have been fatal.

You had to get rid of dummy's singleton ♥ first - the fact that it was a winner should not affect your making the correct play.

Board 2
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q 10 8 4 ♥ A K 5 ♦ 9 8 6 2 ♣ Q 10	
♠ 5 3 ♥ 7 6 ♦ 10 5 ♣ 9 8 6 5 4 3 2	N W E S	♠ A 9 6 ♥ 9 8 4 2 ♦ A K 7 3 ♣ K J
	♠ K J 7 2 ♥ Q J 10 3 ♦ Q J 4 ♣ A 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	Pass	1NT	Pass
2♠	Pass	3♣	
All Pass			

3♣ by East
Lead: ♥Q

Many people play Jacoby Transfer convention. Not all of them play that an initial response of 2♠ asks partner to bid 3♣. You use that here and reply 3♣. Everybody passes.

What a terrible dummy! This shows why this method is a good addition to Jacoby Transfers.

East plays 3♣. South leads the ♥Q. North takes the ♥ A K, then switches to the ♠Q.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = ? :: Total = 3 + ?

Instead of trying to estimate how many ♣ losers you may have, just tell yourself that you can only afford to lose one! Then you base your plan on that requirement.

You might as well win the ♠A. You need to play the trumps from dummy and the easiest way to get there is to play ♦ A K, then ruff a ♦. Now play a ♣ from dummy and play what from your hand?

You may think it is a guess whether to play the ♣K or ♣J, but there is no guessing involved here. You must play the ♣J because North cannot possibly hold the ♣A. Just go back and look at the bidding again. The North hand failed to open the bidding in first seat. And since then you have seen the ♥ A K and the ♠Q come out of the hand. That's 9 points and the ♣A would bring that total to 13. Since he passed it follows that he doesn't have the ♣A. Of course he might or might not have the ♣Q, you just have to hope for that card.

It's easy to forget the bidding once you have started playing a hand.

But good players don't forget, they use every bit of information they can get to help them make their contracts. That's why they make more contracts.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 5 4 ♥ K 9 7 ♦ K 8 6 2 ♣ A Q 5	
♠ Q 8 2 ♥ J 6 4 ♦ J 7 5 ♣ 9 8 7 3		♠ 10 9 6 3 ♥ 10 8 5 2 ♦ Q 10 9 ♣ J 6
	♠ A K J ♥ A Q 3 ♦ A 4 3 ♣ K 10 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2NT
Pass	4NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by South
Lead: ♣9

Partner's 4NT bid is not Blackwood, it is the Quantitative 4NT. He is unsure whether to bid 6NT or not, so is inviting you to do so.

With 20 points you are supposed to pass. With 21 points you are supposed to bid 6NT. The evaluations probably aren't that accurate, but at least you have an excuse to bid 6NT.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♣9. East plays the ♣J which you take with your ♣K.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 11

There are two places you might find your twelfth winner. You can finesse East for the ♠Q; this is a 50% chance. Or, the ♦s might split 3-3; this is about a 40% chance.

If you try the ♠ finesse and it fails you will go down even if the ♦s are splitting 3-3.

If you play ♦A, ♦K then another ♦, a 4-2 ♦ split will defeat you even if the ♠Q was with East.

Two chances are always better than one. The way to take both chances is to duck a ♦ at trick 2. Win whatever the defenders play next and then test the ♦s. If they do split your last ♦ will be trick #12. But if they don't split you can still try the ♠ finesse.

Ducking the ♦ was the correct play - not just because it worked, but because it gave you the opportunity to try an alternate method if it didn't work.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 7 3 ♥ K J 9 ♦ Q J 10 4 ♣ 8 5 2	
♠ K 8 6 2 ♥ 7 5 ♦ A K 7 ♣ A K 6 3	N W E S	♠ A 9 ♥ Q 10 6 3 ♦ 8 5 2 ♣ Q J 9 4
	♠ Q 10 5 4 ♥ A 8 4 2 ♦ 9 6 3 ♣ 10 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♠	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by West
Lead: ♦Q

With 9 points you have just enough to respond. And with a 4-card Major suit you should use Stayman so you bid 2♣. Partner duly replies 2♠.

With 9 points you have just enough to respond. And with a 4-card Major suit you should use Stayman so you bid 2♣. Partner duly replies 2♠.

You don't have a 4-4 ♥ fit, so you invite the notrump game by bidding 2NT. Partner raises to 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by East.

West plays 3NT and North leads the ♦Q. Should you win or hold up?

A pretty good argument against holding up could be that they might switch to ♠s. However, say you do in fact hold up and that North does in fact continue ♦s with South following suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

Don't worry any more about the ♦s since there is nothing more you can do. Instead, worry about where that one more winner is going to come from. The answer will have to be: *from the ♥ suit*.

You might be tempted to take your 4 ♣ tricks right away, but avoid the temptation. The ♣ suit is your convenient transportation back and forth between hands.

You will have to lose at least 2 ♥ tricks in order to set up 1 winner, and by the time you do that the defenders will have established at least 1 more ♦ trick. What that means is that you cannot afford 3 ♥ losers. So how will you play the ♥s?

You should play North for the ♥J plus one of the big ones. This is a better chance than playing him for both the ♥ A K. So play a ♥ toward dummy and insert the ♥10 when North plays low. South wins with the ♥A and clears the ♦s. Play another ♥ toward dummy's ♥Q. North can take his ♥K and cash his ♦ winner but dummy's ♥Q will be your ninth trick.

There were two ♥ distributions which would allow you to make this contract.

North could hold both the ♥A and ♥K, in which case leading toward dummy's ♥Q would be the winning play.

North could hold **EITHER** ♥ A J x **OR**♥ K J x in which case finessing dummy's ♥J would be the winning play. This is the more likely distribution of the two.

Board 5
West Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A 9 5
♥ Q 10 2
♦ K Q 10 6 3
♣ K 8

♠ K Q J 10
♥ K J 9 7 5 4
♦ A
♣ 9 5



♠ 6 4 2
♥ 8 3
♦ 9 7 4
♣ J 10 7 4 3

♠ 8 7 3
♥ A 6
♦ J 8 5 2
♣ A Q 6 2

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♥	1NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥8

overtrick!

You should not make a takeout double with three cards in their suit. A 2♦ overcall would be a reasonable choice. But with 15 points, balanced, and a stopper in ♥s a 1NT overcall is probably better.

Partner bids 3NT.

North plays 3NT. As expected, East leads his partner's ♥ suit.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1/2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 :: Total = 5/6

You need at least 4 ♦ winners.

If you play low from dummy on the ♥ lead West can win the ♥K but this will give you an extra ♥ stopper. He could drive out dummy's ♥A at trick 2, but you would then establish ♦s and make an

But who said West would play another ♥ after winning the ♥K? What if he wins the ♥K and switches to ♠s? They might then win 3 ♠ tricks to go with their ♥K and ♦A.

Instead you should grab the first trick with dummy's ♥A and start playing ♦s. West will take the ♦A but you still have the ♠A and ♥Q as stoppers.

Just look at West's hand. If you duck the ♥A it will be crystal clear to him that he can defeat the contract by winning the ♥K and then switching to the ♠K.

Don't give him the chance.

Board 6
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A Q J 9 7 4 ♥ — ♦ K Q J 3 ♣ J 8 3	
♠ K 6 3 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ A 7 6 2 ♣ A 7 5		♠ 8 5 ♥ Q J 9 7 6 4 2 ♦ 9 ♣ K 9 4
	♠ 10 2 ♥ K 8 3 ♦ 10 8 5 4 ♣ Q 10 6 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	2♠	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by East
Lead: ♠10

You would really like to have a transfer bid in this situation, to make West bid ♥s.

But you don't have one, so you just bid 4♥ yourself.

East plays 4♥. South leads the ♠10. You play low in dummy and South holds the trick. He continues the suit and North takes the ♠Q and then plays the ♠A.

Loser List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

You've already lost the 2 ♠s. If South has the ♥K you might avoid a loser there. You don't have a winner on which to discard the ♣ loser.

If North has the ♥K it will have to be a singleton to help you, so it is more logical to play South for the ♥K. But if South does have the ♥K it will do you no good to ruff North's ♠A, South will over-ruff and you would still have that ♣ loser.

So do it this way instead. Discard the ♣ loser on North's ♠A! Another ♠ from North won't hurt you since dummy would be able to over-ruff South. Whatever North plays you can win, then finesse South out of his ♥K.

It was said earlier that you didn't have a winner on which you could discard the ♣ loser.

That was true, so instead you were able to discard it on a loser!